



Lesson 5: Refusal Skills Practice

Choosing healthy responses to peer pressure

 **In this activity, you will** learn how to effectively use **refusal skills** to handle peer pressure and stay safe in challenging social situations. You will read about the importance of setting boundaries and then practice crafting your own responses to real-life scenarios.



Why Refusal Skills Matter

Building **assertive communication** is an essential life skill. Understanding how to decline offers that conflict with your values or health goals helps you maintain control over your choices, even when you feel social pressure from peers.

Term	Definition
Assertiveness	The ability to express your thoughts and needs clearly and respectfully, without being aggressive or passive.
Peer Pressure	The influence from friends or social groups to act in a certain way to fit in or gain approval.
Refusal Skills	Specific techniques and language used to decline an offer or activity safely and firmly.



Read the Following Text

Read the following passage carefully. As you read, ask yourself: *How does having a pre-planned response help someone stay calm under pressure?*

Navigating social situations can be tricky, especially when friends are involved. Peer pressure often happens when people feel they must say 'yes' to fit in, even if they are uncomfortable or don't want to participate in a specific activity.

Refusal skills are not just about saying 'no.' They are about communicating your decision with confidence and clarity. There are several effective methods you can use:

1. **The Direct No:** Keep it simple and clear. 'No, I don't want to do that.'
2. **The Reasoned No:** State your boundary clearly. 'No thanks, I don't vape, it's not for me.'
3. **The Suggestion Switch:** Offer an alternative. 'No, I don't want to do that, but do you want to grab food instead?'
4. **The Physical Exit:** Sometimes the best refusal is simply leaving the situation. 'I just realized I need to be somewhere else, I'm heading out.'

Developing these skills before you are in a high-pressure situation allows your brain to react faster. When you know exactly what you will say, you are less likely to get caught in the moment or say something you don't mean. Remember, true friends will respect your decisions, even if they disagree with them. By standing your ground, you set a standard for how you expect to be treated.



Answer the Questions

Use the information from the text to answer the following questions.

1. Why is it beneficial to decide on a refusal response before you are actually in a high-pressure situation?

[Write your answer here.]

2. Explain the difference between passive and assertive communication in the context of peer pressure.

3. In Scenario 1 (A friend offers you a vape), which refusal method would you choose, and why?

4. How can using the 'Suggestion Switch' method help you maintain a friendship while still saying no?

5. Why might someone find it difficult to use a 'Physical Exit' when feeling uncomfortable at a party?

